

Ultimate Basic



Current version: **1.5.9**

A modern BASIC-like language that compiles directly to 6502 machine code for the **Commodore 64** and **Commodore 64 Ultimate**. It produces `.prg` files that run in VICE or on real hardware, and can also build `.d64` disk images.

Ultimate Basic looks like classic BASIC but compiles ahead of time — no interpreter, no line numbers required. It adds typed variables (`int` / `word` / `float` / `string` / arrays), subroutines and functions, structured control flow, and direct, high-level access to the C64's hardware: bitmap and block graphics, sprites, SID sound and music, raster/CIA/NMI interrupts, REU transfers, disk I/O, CRT cartridge export, and inline 6502 assembly.

Hires bitmap drawing (`plot`, `line`, `rect`, `circle`, `paint`) picks its color from `color pen c` — a persistent foreground color stamped into each touched cell. Multicolor bitmap mode has its own shape commands — `mplot`, `mline`, `mrect`, and `mcircle` — where the trailing `color` argument selects the 2-bit color source (0–3).

Sprite support includes hardware collision registers, side-effect-free software AABB tests with `box_hit()`, and frame selection from consecutive sprite animation data. Use `sprite_frame id`, `base`, `frame` inside an animation loop to select successive images stored in 64-byte slots; it changes the sprite image only and does not animate or move the sprite automatically.

Character tile maps can be embedded from self-describing `.ubmap` files, rendered as 40×25 viewports, queried and modified at runtime, in normal or multicolor text mode.

Koala Painter images can also be validated, embedded, shown in multicolor bitmap mode, and hidden again with `koala load`, `koala show`, and `koala hide`.

Build

```
cargo build --release      # binary: target/release/ub
cargo test                 # unit + integration tests
cargo install cargo-deb cargo-generate-rpm
cargo deb                  # Debian/Ubuntu package: target/debian/*.deb
cargo generate-rpm         # Fedora/RHEL package: target/generate-rpm/*.rpm
```

The Debian and RPM commands package the release binary as `/usr/bin/ub` and include the README and manual under `/usr/share/doc/ultimate-basic`. The same packages are also built automatically by the `linux-packages` GitHub Actions job on pushes to `main` and can be downloaded from its workflow artifacts.

Usage

```
ub build demo.ub -o demo.prg      # compile to a .prg (prints a memory map)
ub build demo.ub -v               # also print ZP layout + hex dump
ub build demo.ub --debug          # also write .sym, .dbg and .vs symbols
ub build demo.ub --asm            # also write a readable 6502 codegen listing
ub build demo.ub --d64 disk.d64   # also build a .d64 disk image
ub build demo.ub --d64 disk.d64 --add music.prg # embed extra files in the .d64
```

Option	Description
<code>-o, --output <file></code>	Output <code>.prg</code> (default: <code><input>.prg</code>)
<code>-v, --verbose</code>	Print full zero-page layout and a hex dump
<code>--no-stub</code>	Skip the BASIC <code>SYS</code> stub (code loads at <code>\$0801</code>)
<code>--debug</code>	Also produce KickAssembler <code>.sym</code> , C64Debugger <code>.dbg</code> , and VICE <code>.vs</code> files
<code>--asm</code>	Also produce a readable 6502 codegen listing as <code><output>.asm</code>
<code>--d64 [file]</code>	Also produce a <code>.d64</code> (default: <code><output>.d64</code>)
<code>--add <file></code>	Add an extra file to the <code>.d64</code> (repeatable)
<code>--explicit</code>	Require a <code>:type</code> annotation on every <code>var</code> , <code>sub</code> -param, and <code>fn</code> -param

With `--debug`, the compiler writes three files beside the program: an importable KickAssembler `.sym`, a C64Debugger/RetroDebugger `.dbg`, and a VICE monitor `.vs`. They contain the program boundaries, variables, arrays, subroutines, and BASIC labels. The `.dbg` export currently provides address symbols but not source-line stepping data.

With `--asm`, the compiler writes a readable assembly listing beside the program. Unlike a plain disassembly of the finished PRG, it is built from code-generation metadata and retains UB statement comments, zero-page variable names, array/subroutine/BASIC-label symbols, generated branch/JMP/JSR labels, instruction addresses, and emitted machine-code bytes. Compiler-generated helper routines are included in the same listing. The output uses KickAssembler syntax and can be assembled again. Known data regions—such as `data`, maps, sprite/character definitions, lookup tables, SID/Koala payloads, and `incbin` content—are emitted as `.byte` blocks instead of being mistaken for instructions.

What's new in 1.5.9

- **`chain "FILE" [, device]`** loads another program over the running one and RUNs it, as if `LOAD"FILE",8,1 + RUN` had been typed — the missing piece for a boot / title program that shows a picture and then starts the game. A small position-independent loader is copied to the cassette buffer (`$033C`), the I/O is reset (IOINIT, RESTOR, VIC IRQs off), BASIC is re-initialised after the load (so Exomizer `sfx` crunched boot programs work too) and the program is started. If the file cannot be loaded, execution continues after `chain`.

```
koala load "title.koa"
koala show
k = getch()
chain "GAME"
print "LOAD ERROR"
```

- **Fix: `load` secondary address.** `load "FILE"` used secondary address 0 with X/Y = 0, so the file was loaded to `$0000`; `load "FILE", addr` ignored `addr`. Now `load "FILE"` loads to the file's own address and `load "FILE", addr` to `addr`.
- **Fix: `--d64` images with more than one file.** Directory entries were written 30 bytes apart instead of 32, so every file after the first had a broken directory entry (a `--add` ed file could not be loaded). The disk ID / DOS type were also in the wrong BAM bytes, data only used tracks 1–17 (a bigger disk crashed the build), and sectors were written without the 1541 interleave. Images are now laid out as the 1541 DOS writes them (tracks 17→1, then 19→35, interleave 10), and a full disk is a clean build error.

What's new in 1.5.8

- **Initialised arrays:** `data <array>: v, ...` fill a declared `array` / `array_word` with constant values. Several lines continue where the previous one stopped, word arrays take 16-bit values (stored lo, hi), and the table is indexed like any array (`sinus[i]`). The values are stored after the code and copied into the array once at program start, right after the arrays are zeroed. These lines do not affect the `read` stream; more values than the array holds, or an undeclared name, is a compile-time error. This is what the Visual Assembler Curve Editor's "Export to UltimateBasic" generates.

```

var sinus = array(8)
data sinus: 128, 218, 255, 218
data sinus: 128, 37, 0, 37
sprite 0, x, sinus[i]

```

What's new in 1.5.7

New language elements:

- **charset on / charset off** switch the VIC-II to the RAM character set at **charset addr** (and back to the ROM set). Together with **chardef** this is a complete custom-font workflow. A bad base address, or program code that reaches into the set, is a compile-time error.
- **org addr** continues the subroutine code at a later address and leaves the gap free for data, so a big program can live around a charset, sprite data or a font.
- **incbin "file", addr, skip [, len]** skips a **.prg** load address (or any header) and can take just a slice of a file. **incbin ..., addr** may now target an **org** gap.
- **sfx channel, freq, frames [, wave]** is a non-blocking SID note: it returns at once and the envelope fades the note out, so it can be used inside a game loop (**sound** blocks).
- **tune ... end** describes a 3-voice SID tracker tune (instruments, order list and pattern rows such as "C-4 01 V24") directly in the source. The compiler builds a self-contained player at compile time - it uses no zero page - and defines **sid_init** / **sid_play** , so **music play|stop|pause|resume** work as with **load sid** . Vibrato, slide, note cut and speed changes are supported. This is what the Visual Assembler SID editor's "Export to UltimateBasic" generates.

```

tune
  speed 6
  inst 0, $41, $09, $F0, $0800, $0064, $27, $1F
  order 0
  pat 0, 0, "C-4 00", "...", "E-4 00 V24", "...", "G-4 00", "... .. C00"
end
music play

```

```

charset $3800
incbin "font.bin", $3800      # data goes into the gap that `org` leaves
...
org $4000                    # (between two subs) code continues above the charset

```

```

charset on                                # the VIC-II now draws from $3800
sfx 1, $0500, 8, 128                     # a short noise burst; the program keeps running

```

Fixes:

- **music play** stopped after the first tick: its CIA1 IRQ wrapper acknowledged the timer by writing `$01` to `$DC0D` (which clears the interrupt mask) instead of reading it.
- **Inline asm { }** dropped the addressing mode of label operands, so `LDA table,X`, `LDA table,Y` and `JMP (label)` were assembled as plain absolute instructions.
- **sound** lasted half as long as requested and crashed for durations other than 0 (a wrong branch patch). Now it waits on raster line 200 like `delay`.
- **word products** (`score += 300 * level`, `w = 100 * l + 900`) are now computed in 16 bits; they were truncated to 8 bits.
- **print of float expressions** (`print a / 10`) prints `N.DD` instead of the raw Q8.8 integer.
- **Arrays start zeroed** (RAM at power-up holds garbage).
- **Zero page overflow** is a compile-time error (`out of zero page`), and sequential `for` loops share their limit/step bytes instead of exhausting the permanent area.
- The manual no longer claims `%` binary literals (the lexer never supported them) and the `charset` example uses the right `$D018` value.

What's new in 1.5.6

- Added **color pen and multicolor shapes**. `color pen c` sets a persistent hires drawing color (0–15) that `plot`, `line`, `rect`, `circle`, and `paint` stamp into the foreground nibble of every cell they touch (the background nibble is preserved; default white). For multicolor bitmap mode, `mline`, `mrect`, and `mcircle` join `mplot`, each taking a trailing 2-bit `color` (0–3) source:

```

graphics on
gcls
color pen 2
circle 160, 100, 40    # red circle

graphics on multi
gcls
mcircle 80, 100, 40, 1 # multicolor circle
mline 0, 0, 159, 199, 3

```

The multicolor shapes reuse the same Bresenham/midpoint routines as their hires counterparts, plotting each pixel through `mplot`.

What's new in 1.5.5

- Added **Magic Desk CRT export**. Building with an output filename ending in `.crt` now writes a Commodore 64 cartridge image instead of a raw PRG:

```
ub build demo.ub -o demo.crt
```

The cartridge uses the same banked Magic Desk layout as VisualAssembler's CRT export: an 8×8K type-19 image with a boot loader in bank 0 and the compiled PRG payload copied into RAM on startup. Existing `.prg` and `.d64` output paths are unchanged.

- Added integration-test coverage for the CRT packer so the cartridge header, bank layout, payload copy, and boot stub stay stable.
- Added **type ... endtype structs**. Define a fixed layout of `int` (1 byte) or `word` (2 bytes) fields, then allocate an array of instances with the same syntax as any other array:

```
type TEntity
  var x: int
  var y: int
  var hp: word
endtype

const N = 8
var enemies: TEntity = array(N) # N × 4 = 32 bytes at $C000
enemies[0].x = 5
enemies[i].hp = enemies[i].hp + 1
```

Constant indices fold to `LDA/STA absolute`; variable indices emit a shift-and-add `idx * elem_size` multiplier followed by `(ptr),Y` access. See `examples/type_demo.ub`. Struct-typed sub/fn parameters, default field values, and nested struct fields are not yet implemented.

- Count-down for / loop** with negative constant `step` now works correctly. Previously the exit test was unsigned-only, so `for i = 20 to 0 step -2` either ran zero iterations or looped forever depending on whether it wrapped past 0. The compiler now picks the exit-branch encoding from the sign of the constant `step`, and emits an extra post-increment `BCS` check that catches the 8-bit underflow when counting down to (or through) 0.
- A `for / loop` with default `step +1` where `from > to` — e.g. `for i = 10 to 1` — used to skip the body silently. It is now a compile-time error directing you to `step -1`:

```
for-loop: from (10) > to (1) with default step +1 loops 0 times
  - use 'step -1' to count down
```

- Added the `--explicit` CLI flag. When passed to `ub build`, every `var`, `sub`-param, and `fn`-param declaration must carry a `:type` annotation; arrays and `const` are unaffected. The flag is a build-time switch, so nothing in the source changes to opt in or out. See `examples/explicit_demo.ub` and `examples/explicit_errors_demo.ub`.
- Added `examples/countdown_demo.ub` and `examples/countdown_errors_demo.ub`, plus new integration tests that both check the emitted branch encoding and run the loop on the test CPU to confirm it terminates.

What's new in 1.5.3

- Added **multi-dimensional arrays**. Declare an array with a comma-separated dimension list and index it the same way; storage is row-major and the total size is the product of the dimensions:

```
var grid = array(8, 8)      # 8x8 = 64 bytes
grid[r, c] = 42             # row-major: base + r*8 + c
var v = grid[r, c]
var wm = array_word(4, 4)   # word (16-bit) elements work too
```

Any number of dimensions is supported, dimensions may be `const`s, all-constant subscripts fold to a direct address at compile time, and a single subscript into a multi-dimensional array is still allowed as flat/linear access.

- Fixed PETSCII string encoding of `[`, `]`, and `^`, which previously printed as `?`. They now emit their correct C64 codes (`$5B`, `$5D`, `$5E`) in both the uppercase and lowercase charset modes.
- Added `examples/array2d_demo.ub` and integration tests for multi-dimensional arrays and the bracket encoding.

What's new in 1.5.2

- Added `ub build <file.ub> --asm` and `<file>.asm` codegen listings.
- Listings retain UB statement boundaries and compiler symbols instead of producing only a bare post-build disassembly.
- Zero-page variables and arrays are emitted as named assembler constants.

- BASIC labels, subroutines, relative branches, and generated in-program JMP/JSR targets receive readable labels.
- Every instruction includes its C64 address and generated machine-code bytes, making the output useful for inspection, debugging, optimization, and comparison with the PRG.
- Compiler helpers use descriptive `ub_helper_*` labels, while known embedded data is emitted with named `.byte` regions in reassemblable KickAssembler syntax.
- Added listing tests and documentation in the README, manual, CLI help, release notes, and compiler developer guide.

Documentation

The complete language and CLI reference lives in `**[MANUAL.md](MANUAL.md)**` – variables and types, operators, control flow, subroutines/functions, graphics (bitmap, double-buffered, block), sprites, sound and SID music, interrupts, REU, disk I/O, string/math functions, and inline assembly.

Release history is in `[whatnews.txt](whatnews.txt)`.

Examples

Ready-to-build demos are in `[`examples/`](examples/)` – bitmap and block graphics, sprite multiplexing, plasma and orbit effects, a flicker-free double-buffered 3D cube (``cube_demo.ub``), REU stash/fetch, SID music playback, scrollers, and more.